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no choice, India will have to replace them. She may have divulged details of other undercover officials posted in neighbouring missions.

Officials, however, maintain that Gupta didn't have access to any classified information which is disbursed on a need-to-know basis. "She is a disgruntled employee who had little real-time information to give. In any case, classified information like top secret telegrams are well-secured," said an official, but the cause for concern is the security of the Indian mission since it has been on the hit list of terrorist groups for a while. Besides, if Gupta did have access to senior intelligence officials in the mission chances are that she may have also compromised other undercover Indian assets in Pakistan who are handled by these officials.

Authorities believe that the daring theft of a laptop and briefcase containing sensitive papers from the Indian High Commissioner's residence in 2007 could also be linked to the Gupta spy ring, as the Pakistan operatives were tipped off by an insider. Being a difficult family station, the mission staffers are a close-knit group and celebrate festivals and community events together. In fact, Gupta took the lead at organising several social functions at the High Commission of India club. Interestingly, much of the information



“The fact that she was called back to Delhi indicates that the charges against her were serious.”

S.M. KRISHNA,
EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTER



“My information is as good as yours as it is based on media reports. India has shared nothing with us.”

SHAH MAHMOOD QURESHI,
PAKISTAN FOREIGN MINISTER

she gathered was at such functions and informal gatherings. "She was quite friendly and outgoing, we never suspected any thing but sometimes she would disappear and often go out for drives alone; she loved to drive fast cars," remarks a former colleague. At a recent do, she even boasted about getting a plum posting to Washington D.C. or London soon.

While so far Gupta has revealed that she supplied information to the Pakistani intelligence on Indo-Afghan relations, the composite dialogue process and the 26/11

GUPTA'S EAST DELHI RESIDENCE

probe, sources reveal that one of her recent updates was on the SAARC summit in Bhutan, which her handlers were keen to know about.

Another linkage is being drawn to the February attack in Kabul where the suspected Taliban militants went around with specific names believed to be of some Indian intelligence officials. For the MEA, the incident comes as a big embarrassment because this level of espionage has never hit the foreign service, that too in a sensitive mission where a background check is done on each staffer. Yet through all this, officials are busy scanning when she was compromised—in her earlier postings in Baghdad, Malaysia or when she was working at the Indian Council for World Affairs, which she had lobbied for. Sources confirmed that Gupta volunteered to go to Pakistan. Now, security officials are busy sanitising the Indian mission, going through documents and information she may have had access to.

While Pakistan has maintained this is India's internal matter, diplomatic sources in Islamabad believe that the timing of the scandal just ahead of the Manmohan-Gilani talks is suspicious. They believe that India may use the excuse of Gupta's case to further stall any forward movement in the dialogue process.

But the spy game will certainly add to the mistrust between the two countries. Besides the Government must investigate why top High Commission officials were caught napping as a junior employee ran a spy ring under their noses for more than two years.

The Gupta scandal has also brought the turf war between the MEA and the two intelligence agencies the R&AW and the Intelligence Bureau out in the open. Accountability must be fixed for senior officials because Islamabad, one of India's most sensitive and most important diplomatic missions, has been penetrated and has dealt a major blow to India's national security apparatus.

*with Hasan Zaidi in Karachi and
Bhavna Vij-Aurora*